The Lighten Road
Game Design Document

Title & The Pitch

Title: The Lighten Road

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Pitch: A tense, atmospheric 2D puzzle-platformer where a terrified explorer in a post-apocalyptic world must carefully manage the fuel of a mysterious lantern to navigate pitch-black ruins.

Target Player(Bartle)

Primary Type: Explorer

Secondary Type: Achiever

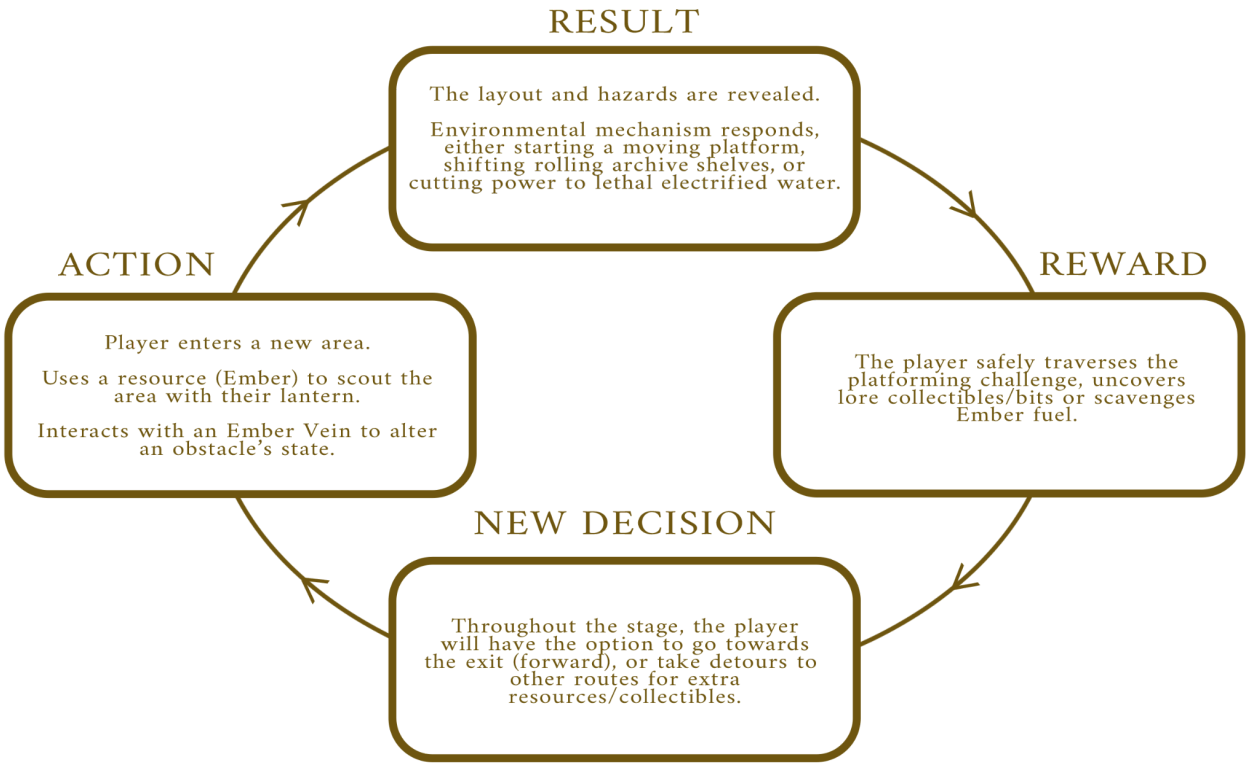
The Explorer is served by the game's emphasis on revealing hidden lore fragments and navigating atmospheric environments.

The Achiever is rewarded by mastering the tight fuel economy, optimizing movement routes, and perfectly executing the "Power vs. Drain" mechanic to overcome complex puzzles.

Target Player Experience

"The Lighten Road is meant to give the players a feeling of what our world would look like 400 years later if it was hit by an apocalypse today. The crushing sense of loneliness, the fear of the dark, the tension of the unknown, the rewarding relief of overcoming seemingly impossible odds, and ironically the comfort of peering into the shadows only to realize that you're completely alone. That's what we're trying to go for."

Core Loop



Exiting a solved room seals the doorway behind the player and drops them directly into the pitch darkness of the next stage. The resources remaining from the previous room directly determine how freely the player can flare their lantern in the next, making fuel conservation a cumulative challenge across the level.

Session Start: The player finds themselves at the entrance of a sealed sector of the ruins with a basic ember supply, a dimly glowing lantern, and an unpowered path ahead.
Session End: A successful session ends when the player reaches the end of a stage and unlocks the threshold to the next zone. A failed session ends when the player falls into a lethal hazard or depletes all ember fuel in the dark, resulting in resource loss and respawning at the start of the current stage.

Mechanics

Controls and Actions

- Move left and right, jump.
- Toggle the lantern between "Dim" (passive glow) and "Flare" (wide visibility but drains fuel).
- Interact with ancient "Ember Veins" in the environment to either Power nearby mechanical obstacles (spending a portion of lantern fuel) or Drain active mechanisms (absorbing their energy into the lantern while shutting down the connected device).
- The player **cannot** sprint, double-jump, or attack.

Goals, Win, and Lose Conditions

The primary goal is to navigate through segmented puzzle stages and escape the ruin.

The win condition on a big scale is reaching the final stage and activating the Old World archive. On a small scale it's finishing a puzzle and reaching the next stage.

The lose condition occurs when the player falls into a lethal hazard or completely runs out of lantern fuel, resulting in death, the loss of scavenged resources, and respawning at the start of the current stage.

Meaningful Choice

The core choices are "Vision vs. Survival" and "Power vs. Drain".

Flaring the lantern reveals safe paths and hidden items but rapidly burns life-saving fuel, while dimming it conserves fuel but forces blind, risky leaps. Additionally, players must choose when to power Ember Veins to move platforms and when to drain them to freeze/stop hazards.

Player Feedback

Activating an Ember Vein provides audio-visual confirmation via a surge sound, glowing neon cables, and mechanical shifting audio. When lantern fuel drops below 25%, the light flickers erratically and an ambient heartbeat sound effect intensifies.

Feedback Loop (Positive)

The game features a systemic positive feedback loop (death spiral) tied to resource depletion. Inefficient routing burns excess fuel, causing the player to use the lantern's powers less on later stages; a smaller field of view makes platforming hazards harder to anticipate, which further penalizes fuel conservation and raises survival tension.

Elemental Tetrad

ELEMENT	SUMMARY
Mechanics	2D precision puzzle-platforming with dynamic vision radius management, route memorization, and an active Ember Vein system (Powering vs. Draining environmental machinery).
Story	Light, a condemned "Ruin Researcher" armed only with an anomalous ember lantern, is forced into a pitch-black pre-Fall ruin to scavenge ancient technology in exchange for his freedom. As he navigates the silent, decaying facility, his struggle for survival leads directly into a classified subterranean archive that holds the catastrophic truth behind The Fall itself.
Aesthetics	Pure 2D high-contrast pixel art. Pitch-black voids framed against the warm glow of the lantern and pulsating neon Ember Vein conduits. Decaying, desolate corporate brutalism transitioning into cold, clinical laboratory corridors, emphasizing deep isolation and atmospheric dread.
Technology	Unity 2D Engine, C# scripting, Unity Tilemap System, URP, 2D Lighting for dynamic radial FOV, light-masking vision cones

Scope & Feasibility

Dimension & Perspective

Pure 2D side-scrolling puzzle-platformer.

Levels & Session

4 to 5 segmented puzzle chambers split across two distinct thematic zones:
Zone 1 (Abandoned Corporate Archive) and Zone 2 (Subterranean Covert Lab).

A complete run takes approximately 15 to 20 minutes of gameplay, with individual puzzle chambers lasting 2 to 4 minutes each.

Minimum Viable Product (MVP)

The first 2 Office chapters/stages fully functional in pure 2D pixel art.

Complete implementation of the core character controller, the lantern's Dim/Flare fuel economy, and the base Ember Vein mechanic (Powering and Draining rolling archive shelves, one lift, and electrified water hazards).

Cuts / Contingency

If development time runs short, the entire Zone 2 (Secret Laboratory) and its advanced sci-fi obstacles (cryo-stasis tanks, laser containment fields, and ventilation turbines) will be cut completely.

Scope will scale down strictly to polishing the narrative arc, art assets, and puzzle pacing of the 2 Office chapters as a self-contained full playthrough.